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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

House approves stopgap funding

Measure to temporarily avert shutdown doesn't raise the debt ceiling, despite Trump's demands

By Lisa Mascaro, Farnoush Amiri and Matt Brown
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — Hours to go before a midnight government shutdown, the House approved a new plan late Friday from Speaker Mike Johnson that would temporarily fund federal operations

and disaster aid, but drops President-elect Donald Trump's demands for a debt limit increase into the new year. Johnson insisted Congress would "meet our obligations" and not allow federal operations to shutter ahead of the Christmas holiday season. But the day's outcome was uncertain after Trump doubled down on his insis-

tence that a debt ceiling increase be included in any deal — if not, he said in an early morning post, let the closures "start now." The bill was approved 366-34, and now goes to the Senate, for expected quick passage. "We're excited about this outcome," Johnson said afterward, adding that he had spoken with Trump, and the president-elect "was certainly happy about this outcome, as well." It was the third attempt from Johnson, the beleaguered House

speaker, to achieve one of the basic requirements of the federal government — keeping it open. And it raised stark questions about whether Johnson will be able to keep his job, in the face of angry GOP colleagues, and work alongside Trump and billionaire ally Elon Musk, who have called the legislative plays this time. Trump's last-minute demand was almost an impossible ask, and Johnson had almost no choice but to work around his pressure for a debt ceiling increase.

The speaker knew there wouldn't be enough support within the GOP majority to pass any funding package, since many Republicans prefer to slash federal government and certainly wouldn't allow more debt. Instead, the Republicans, who will have full control of the White House, House and Senate next year, with big plans for tax cuts and other priorities, are showing that they must routinely rely on Demo-

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TESS CROWLEY/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Santa makes CPS stop

Santa Claus and Children First Fund representatives hand out donated gifts to pre-kindergarten student Tristin Lacy, center, and others at Jackie Robinson Elementary School in Chicago on Friday. The gifts were part of the CPS Santa Program in which students send letters to Santa, including a wish list, and are matched with local businesses and community partners.

At library, reading beneath the lines

By Peter Breen
Chicago Tribune

The ancient manuscript rested on the shelves of the Newberry Library for more than a century. Little was known about the bound book from colonial Mexico that had been donated to the library in 1911 by Edward Ayer, a collector and a tycoon who made his fortune supplying ties to railroad companies. It was called "Ayer 1485" in the library's catalog. But then, two years ago, pages of the manuscript were projected onto the big screen at a Nahuatl conference at Harvard University where experts of the Aztec language had gathered, their first conference since the pandemic. It was like a family reunion, one

Newberry discovers it holds largest example in existence of extremely rare paper type



Director of Conservation Kim Nichols shines a light through a page of "Ayer 1485," a Nahuatl-language manuscript, at the Newberry Library in Chicago on Dec. 11. EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

attendee remembered. At the podium was Ben Leeming, an independent scholar who studies Nahuatl writings used to evangelize Native peoples. While Leeming showed images of the manuscript — a collection of sermons by famed Franciscan missionary Bernardino de Sahagún — and discussed the significance of the words on its pages, Barbara Mundy became slightly preoccupied with the pages themselves. "Of course I'm interested in the text, but what really, really drew my attention was the slides of different pages from this manuscript," said Mundy, a Tulane University art history professor. "And I said, 'Ben, could we zoom in

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ComEd grid plan contains rate hike

Upgrades set to cost customers more than \$600M over 4 years

By Jeremy Gorner and Robert Channick
Chicago Tribune

The Illinois Commerce Commission on Thursday approved a revised multi-year power grid improvement plan that would increase electric bills for Commonwealth Edison customers by more than \$600 million over four years, 11% less than the utility proposed. The decision comes a year after the ICC rejected another grid plan from ComEd — which would have been more costly for consumers — for reasons that included a failure to show the cost-effectiveness of proposed system investments and not fully complying with the clean-energy goals set by Illinois' ambitious Climate and Equitable Jobs Act. At the time, the utility's plan projected a fivefold jump in solar power systems, increased demands from electric vehicles and the need for infrastructure upgrades to address severe weather caused by climate change. The plan from ComEd approved by the ICC would require \$1.5 billion in investments and improvements needed to strengthen power grid reliability. The approved grid plan will result in an average increase of \$1.84 to monthly residential bills each year, beginning in 2025 through 2027, according to ComEd. Total average monthly bills for ComEd residential customers are currently about \$100, the utility said. The ICC said the effect of its decision on individual customers would vary based on service class and energy usage. But the commission also said that despite the lower utility rate increase for the next four years of \$606 million, ComEd's return on equity, or its profit rate, of 8.9% would not change. "After extensive review, the Commission is confident that both ComEd and Ameren have the tools necessary to make

the Illinois Department of Natural Resources. Ginger Creek in Oak Brook is connected to other bodies of water so there's a high chance that hydrilla has spread. "The system does not exist in a little bubble," Snyder said. The department

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'Bad for everything:' Invasive plant found in DuPage County

By Vivian La
Chicago Tribune

One of the world's most invasive aquatic plants is now in DuPage County, much to the concern of researchers and state officials. But they said the discovery underscores how public education can keep this invasive species and

others out of Illinois waterways. Hydrilla, an aquatic plant native to Europe and Asia, was discovered in October in Oak Brook. It's a prolific grower, experts said, requiring little light or nutrients. As a result, hydrilla "explosions" can decimate local ecosystems and the economies that depend on clear waterways.

"It's bad for everything," said Greg Spyreas, a botanist with the Illinois Natural History Survey. Cold winter temperatures won't stop hydrilla growth, either. The plant can survive at the bottom of lakes that typically don't freeze in the winter. This is the second time hydrilla has been discovered in Illinois

since 2019, according to the U.S. Geological Survey. The first time, the aquatic plant was eradicated quickly after being found in a pond where output to the Des Plaines River could be easily monitored. But the current situation is worse, said Claire Snyder, a natural resources specialist who works with aquatic invasive species at

the Illinois Department of Natural Resources. Ginger Creek in Oak Brook is connected to other bodies of water so there's a high chance that hydrilla has spread. "The system does not exist in a little bubble," Snyder said. The department

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